

# COFINITE ZEROS OF HIGH DERIVATIVES

ERIC HOU

## Abstract

We construct a transcendental entire function  $f$  for which every nonempty open subset of the complex plane contains a zero of  $f^{(n)}$  for all sufficiently large  $n$ . Thus every strictly increasing sequence of derivative orders has zero sets with dense union. The construction uses a random Fock series with independent coefficients uniformly distributed on the closed unit disk. A saddle-point estimate selects a Taylor coefficient with a lower bound at the natural scale. Combining one-coordinate anti-concentration with the mean value property of  $\log |f^{(n)}|$  yields a summable bound for the probability that  $f^{(n)}$  is zero-free on a fixed disk. Every sample satisfies  $|f(z)| \leq \sqrt{2} \exp(|z|^2)$ . The resulting function is a counterexample to Boas and Reddy's printed assertion that every transcendental entire function of order at most two and finite type admits an arbitrarily large fixed disk zero-free for infinitely many successive derivatives.

2020 *Mathematics subject classification*: primary 30D20; secondary 30B20, 30C15, 60F15.

*Keywords and phrases*: entire function, successive derivatives, zero sets, random analytic function, hole probability.

## 1. Introduction

Erdős asked whether there is a nonzero entire function  $f$  such that, for every strictly increasing sequence  $(n_k)_{k \geq 0}$  of nonnegative integers, the union of the zero sets of  $f^{(n_k)}$  is dense in the complex plane [7, p. 72]. The question is recorded as Problem 906 on the Erdős problems page [2]. If polynomials are admitted the question is immediate, because every sufficiently high derivative of a polynomial vanishes identically; we therefore treat the transcendental form of the problem. Throughout, *transcendental entire* means entire and not a polynomial, and  $\mathbb{N} = \{0, 1, 2, \dots\}$ . For  $c \in \mathbb{C}$  and  $R > 0$  we write  $B(c, R) = \{z \in \mathbb{C} : |z - c| < R\}$ .

For a nonempty open set  $U \subset \mathbb{C}$  and an entire function  $f$ , define

$$A_U(f) = \{n \in \mathbb{N} : f^{(n)} \text{ has a zero in } U\}.$$

The following elementary reformulation isolates the quantifier that the problem requires.

LEMMA 1.1. *For an entire function  $f$ , the following assertions are equivalent.*

(1) For every strictly increasing sequence  $(n_k)_{k \geq 0}$  in  $\mathbb{N}$ , the set

$$\bigcup_{k \geq 0} \{z \in \mathbb{C} : f^{(n_k)}(z) = 0\}$$

is dense in  $\mathbb{C}$ .

(2) For every nonempty open set  $U \subset \mathbb{C}$ , the set  $A_U(f)$  is cofinite in  $\mathbb{N}$ , that is,  $\mathbb{N} \setminus A_U(f)$  is finite.

PROOF. Assume (2). Fix a strictly increasing sequence  $(n_k)$  and a nonempty open set  $U$ . Since  $A_U(f)$  is cofinite there is an integer  $N(U)$  such that  $n \geq N(U)$  implies  $n \in A_U(f)$ . The sequence  $(n_k)$  is unbounded, so  $n_k \geq N(U)$  for some  $k$ , and then  $f^{(n_k)}$  has a zero in  $U$ . The displayed union therefore meets every nonempty open set and is dense.

Conversely, suppose that (2) fails. Then for some nonempty open set  $U$  the set  $\mathbb{N} \setminus A_U(f)$  is infinite; enumerate it increasingly as  $(n_k)$ . Each  $f^{(n_k)}$  is zero-free in  $U$ , so the union of their zero sets misses  $U$  and is not dense.  $\square$

THEOREM 1.2. *There exists a transcendental entire function  $f$  such that, for every nonempty open set  $U \subset \mathbb{C}$ , there is an integer  $N(U)$  for which*

$$n \geq N(U) \implies f^{(n)} \text{ has a zero in } U.$$

*The same function can be chosen to satisfy*

$$|f(z)| \leq \sqrt{2} \exp(|z|^2), \quad z \in \mathbb{C}. \quad (1)$$

*Consequently, the zero sets indexed by every strictly increasing sequence of derivative orders have dense union.*

The bound (1) implies that the function below has order at most two and, if its order is two, type at most one. The Boas–Reddy consequence, with its source quantifier made explicit, is recorded in Section 4.

Two classical constructions come close to the statement of Theorem 1.2 without reaching it. MacLane [9] built an entire function whose sequence of successive derivatives is dense, in the topology of locally uniform convergence, in the space of all entire functions. Barth and Schneider [1] showed that, for any sequence  $(S_k)_{k \geq 0}$  of discrete subsets of  $\mathbb{C}$ , one can choose derivative orders  $n_k$  and a transcendental entire function whose  $n_k$ -th derivative vanishes on  $S_k$ . Both results yield density statements near the one asked for, in that they force a union of derivative zero sets to be dense; neither yields assertion (2) of Lemma 1.1.

MacLane’s theorem controls the derivatives only through approximation in the locally uniform topology, which does not preclude an infinite set of derivative orders whose zero sets all miss one fixed disk. In the Barth–Schneider theorem the orders  $n_k$  are produced by the construction rather than prescribed in advance, so the conclusion concerns one increasing sequence and not every one. By Lemma 1.1 the problem is exactly the passage from infinitely many admissible derivative orders to cofinitely many, and it is that passage which the construction below supplies.

The online record labels the problem `OPEN` while cautioning that its status may miss relevant literature [2]. Our argument is self-contained.

The method is probabilistic and belongs to the theory of random analytic functions; for the general theory of random series of functions we refer to Kahane [8]. The quantity estimated in Section 3, the probability that a random analytic function has no zero in a fixed disk, is a hole probability.

The proof is organised as follows. Section 2 introduces a random Fock series whose coefficients are bounded by one, so that the growth bound (1) holds for every sample, and establishes the two deterministic estimates behind the argument: a saddle-point lower bound selecting a Taylor coefficient of  $f^{(n)}$  whose magnitude is bounded below at the relevant scale on a given circle, and a matching upper bound for the whole series. Anti-concentration in that one coefficient converts the lower bound into a pointwise tail estimate for the logarithmic deficit of  $f^{(n)}$ , which is then averaged over a circle.

In Section 3, zero-freeness of  $f^{(n)}$  on a disk forces, through the mean value property of  $\log |f^{(n)}|$ , a large averaged deficit on the boundary circle, an event of small probability. The resulting hole probabilities are summable in  $n$ ; the first Borel–Cantelli lemma [6, Section 2.3] applied along a countable base of disks then produces a single sample with the required property.

## 2. A bounded random Fock series

Let  $\overline{\mathbb{D}}$  be the closed unit disk and let  $m_{\mathbb{D}}$  be normalised planar Lebesgue measure on  $\overline{\mathbb{D}}$ . Put

$$\Omega = \overline{\mathbb{D}}^{\mathbb{N}}, \quad \mathcal{F} = \mathcal{B}(\overline{\mathbb{D}})^{\otimes \mathbb{N}}, \quad \mathbb{P} = m_{\mathbb{D}}^{\otimes \mathbb{N}},$$

and equip  $\Omega$  with the product topology. A countable product of compact metric spaces is compact and metrizable, and  $\mathcal{F}$  is the Borel  $\sigma$ -algebra of  $\Omega$ . For  $\omega = (\omega_k)_{k \geq 0} \in \Omega$  set  $\xi_k(\omega) = \omega_k$ . The coordinate variables  $\xi_0, \xi_1, \dots$  are then independent and uniformly distributed on  $\overline{\mathbb{D}}$ . Define

$$f(z) = \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} \xi_k \frac{z^k}{\sqrt{k!}}. \quad (2)$$

The bound  $|\xi_k| \leq 1$  gives normal convergence on compact subsets of  $\mathbb{C}$ , uniformly in  $\omega$ . Hence every sample defines an entire function, term by term differentiation is legitimate, and for  $n \geq 0$ ,

$$F_n(z) := f^{(n)}(z) = \sum_{m=0}^{\infty} \xi_{n+m} \frac{\sqrt{(n+m)!}}{m!} z^m. \quad (3)$$

The partial sums of (3) are continuous on  $\Omega \times \mathbb{C}$  and converge uniformly on  $\Omega \times \{|z| \leq M\}$  for every  $M$ : the absolute-value majorant has successive-term ratio  $M \sqrt{n+m+1}/(m+1) \rightarrow 0$ . Hence  $(\omega, z) \mapsto F_n(\omega, z)$  is jointly continuous; in particular  $\omega \mapsto F_n(\omega, z)$  is  $\mathcal{F}$ -measurable for each fixed  $z$ . The law  $m_{\mathbb{D}}$  has no atoms, so  $\mathbb{P}\{\xi_k = 0\} = 0$  for every  $k$ , and therefore

$$\Omega_0 = \{\omega \in \Omega : \xi_k(\omega) \neq 0 \text{ for every } k \geq 0\} \quad (4)$$

has  $\mathbb{P}(\Omega_0) = 1$ . On  $\Omega_0$  all Taylor coefficients in (2) are nonzero, so  $f$  is not a polynomial.

The bounded coefficients also give the growth bound. By Cauchy–Schwarz with weights  $2^{k/2}$ ,

$$\begin{aligned} |f(z)| &\leq \sum_{k \geq 0} \frac{|z|^k}{\sqrt{k!}} \\ &\leq \left( \sum_{k \geq 0} \frac{2^k |z|^{2k}}{k!} \right)^{1/2} \left( \sum_{k \geq 0} 2^{-k} \right)^{1/2} = \sqrt{2} \exp(|z|^2). \end{aligned}$$

Thus (1) holds for every  $\omega \in \Omega$ , and every sample has order at most two and finite type.

For  $r \geq 0$  write

$$a_{n,m}(r) = \frac{\sqrt{(n+m)!}}{m!} r^m, \quad S_n(r) = \sum_{m=0}^{\infty} a_{n,m}(r),$$

and set

$$p_n(z) = \frac{1}{2} \log(n!) + |z| \sqrt{n}, \quad L_n = 2 + \log(n+1). \quad (5)$$

We use the extended-real convention  $\log 0 = -\infty$ . Every occurrence of  $L_n$  below is under hypotheses that force  $n \geq 1$ .

The saddle-point estimate needs an upper bound for  $\log(m!)$ . Rather than import a Stirling inequality we prove the following weaker bound, whose loss relative to Stirling's estimate is one logarithm; only the property  $L_n = o(\sqrt{n})$  is used, so the loss is harmless.

LEMMA 2.1 (Elementary factorial bound). *For every integer  $m \geq 1$ ,*

$$\log(m!) \leq m \log m - m + \log(m+1) + 1.$$

PROOF. The function  $\log$  is nondecreasing on  $[1, \infty)$ , so  $\log j \leq \int_j^{j+1} \log t \, dt$  for every integer  $j \geq 1$ . Summing over  $1 \leq j \leq m$  and evaluating the integral,

$$\log(m!) = \sum_{j=1}^m \log j \leq \int_1^{m+1} \log t \, dt = [t \log t - t]_1^{m+1} = (m+1) \log(m+1) - m.$$

Furthermore  $(m+1) \log(m+1) = m \log(m+1) + \log(m+1)$ , and since  $\log(1+u) \leq u$  for  $u \geq 0$ ,

$$m \log(m+1) = m \log m + m \log\left(1 + \frac{1}{m}\right) \leq m \log m + 1.$$

Combining the two displays gives the assertion.  $\square$

LEMMA 2.2 (Saddle estimates). *Let  $n \geq 1$ .*

(1) If  $r \geq 0$ ,  $1 \leq r\sqrt{n}$  and  $r \leq \sqrt{n}$ , then, for  $m = \lfloor r\sqrt{n} \rfloor$ ,

$$\log a_{n,m}(r) \geq \frac{1}{2} \log(n!) + r\sqrt{n} - 2 - \log(n+1);$$

by (5) the right-hand side equals  $p_n(z) - L_n$  for every  $z$  with  $|z| = r$ .

(2) For every  $r \geq 0$ ,

$$\log S_n(r) \leq \frac{1}{2} \log(n!) + r\sqrt{n} + \frac{r+r^2}{2}.$$

Consequently, if  $|z| \leq R$  then

$$\log |F_n(z)| - p_n(z) \leq \frac{R+R^2}{2} \quad (6)$$

for every  $\omega \in \Omega$ , with the inequality read trivially when  $F_n(z) = 0$ .

PROOF. Factor  $a_{n,m}(r) = \sqrt{n!} b_{n,m}(r)$ , where

$$b_{n,m}(r) = \frac{\sqrt{(n+1)(n+2)\cdots(n+m)}}{m!} r^m,$$

which is legitimate because  $(n+m)! = n!(n+1)(n+2)\cdots(n+m)$ .

For (1) put  $x = r\sqrt{n}$ . Each of the  $m$  factors under the square root is at least  $n$ , so  $b_{n,m}(r) \geq n^{m/2} r^m / m! = x^m / m!$ . For  $m = \lfloor x \rfloor$  the hypotheses give  $1 \leq m \leq x \leq n$ , since  $x \geq 1$  and  $x = r\sqrt{n} \leq \sqrt{n}\sqrt{n} = n$ . By Lemma 2.1,

$$\log \frac{x^m}{m!} \geq m \log x - m \log m + m - \log(m+1) - 1 = m \log \frac{x}{m} + m - \log(m+1) - 1.$$

Here  $m \log(x/m) \geq 0$  because  $m \leq x$ ; also  $m > x - 1$  and  $\log(m+1) \leq \log(n+1)$  because  $m \leq n$ . Hence

$$\log \frac{x^m}{m!} \geq (x-1) - \log(n+1) - 1 = x - 2 - \log(n+1),$$

and adding  $\frac{1}{2} \log(n!)$  to both sides gives (1); the identification of the right-hand side with  $p_n(z) - L_n$  is the definition (5).

For (2), note that

$$b_{n,m}(r) = \sqrt{\frac{\binom{n+m}{n}}{m!}} r^m.$$

If  $r > 0$ , put  $t = r/(r + \sqrt{n}) \in (0, 1)$ . Then

$$\frac{\binom{n+m}{n} r^{2m}}{m!} = \left( \binom{n+m}{n} t^m \right) \frac{(r^2/t)^m}{m!}.$$

Cauchy–Schwarz, the binomial series  $\sum_{m \geq 0} \binom{n+m}{n} t^m = (1-t)^{-(n+1)}$  and the exponential series give

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{m \geq 0} b_{n,m}(r) &\leq \left( \sum_{m \geq 0} \binom{n+m}{n} t^m \right)^{1/2} \left( \sum_{m \geq 0} \frac{(r^2/t)^m}{m!} \right)^{1/2} \\ &= (1-t)^{-(n+1)/2} \exp\left(\frac{r^2}{2t}\right). \end{aligned}$$

Put  $u = r/\sqrt{n}$ . Since  $\log(1+u) \leq u$  for  $u \geq 0$  and  $\sqrt{n} \geq 1$ ,

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{n+1}{2} \log(1+u) + \frac{r(r+\sqrt{n})}{2} &\leq \frac{(n+1)r}{2\sqrt{n}} + \frac{r^2+r\sqrt{n}}{2} \\ &= r\sqrt{n} + \frac{r}{2\sqrt{n}} + \frac{r^2}{2} \\ &\leq r\sqrt{n} + \frac{r+r^2}{2}. \end{aligned}$$

Adding  $\frac{1}{2} \log(n!)$  gives (2) for  $r > 0$ ; the case  $r = 0$  is immediate because  $S_n(0) = \sqrt{n!}$ . Finally  $|\xi_{n+m}| \leq 1$ , so (3) and the triangle inequality give  $|F_n(z)| \leq S_n(|z|)$ . Applying the bound just proved with  $r = |z|$ , and using that  $r \mapsto (r+r^2)/2$  is nondecreasing, gives (6) whenever  $|z| \leq R$ .  $\square$

The second ingredient is anti-concentration. If  $\xi$  is uniform on  $\overline{\mathbb{D}}$  then, for  $a \neq 0$ ,  $w \in \mathbb{C}$  and  $\varepsilon \geq 0$ ,

$$\mathbb{P}\{|a\xi + w| < \varepsilon\} \leq \left(\frac{\varepsilon}{|a|}\right)^2, \quad (7)$$

because the set  $\{\zeta : |a\zeta + w| < \varepsilon\}$  is the disk of centre  $-w/a$  and radius  $\varepsilon/|a|$ , whose normalised area is at most  $(\varepsilon/|a|)^2$ .

**LEMMA 2.3** (Pointwise logarithmic tail). *Let  $n \geq 1$  and let  $z \in \mathbb{C}$  satisfy  $1 \leq |z| \sqrt{n}$  and  $|z| \leq \sqrt{n}$ . Then, for every  $s \geq 0$ ,*

$$\mathbb{P}\{p_n(z) - \log |F_n(z)| > s + L_n\} \leq e^{-2s}. \quad (8)$$

**PROOF.** Put  $m = \lfloor |z| \sqrt{n} \rfloor$  and  $k = n + m$ , and split (3) by isolating the coefficient  $\xi_k$ :

$$F_n(\omega, z) = a \xi_k(\omega) + w(\omega),$$

where

$$a = \frac{\sqrt{(n+m)!}}{m!} z^m$$

is deterministic and

$$w(\omega) = \sum_{j \neq m} \xi_{n+j}(\omega) \frac{\sqrt{(n+j)!}}{j!} z^j$$

is the remainder. We first check that  $w$  is finite and measurable. The series defining  $w$  converges absolutely for every  $\omega$ , since  $|\xi_{n+j}| \leq 1$  and  $\sum_{j \geq 0} a_{n,j}(|z|) = S_n(|z|) < \infty$  by Lemma 2.2(2); so  $w$  is finite everywhere, not merely almost surely. It is also a measurable function of  $\omega$ , being a uniform limit of continuous functions on  $\Omega$ . The independence needed below comes from the fact that  $w$  does not depend on the coordinate  $\omega_k$ : it is measurable with respect to  $\mathcal{G} = \sigma(\xi_j : j \neq k)$ , since the index  $j = m$  is omitted from the sum. Note also that  $|z| \geq 1/\sqrt{n} > 0$ , so  $a \neq 0$  and  $|a| = a_{n,m}(|z|)$ .

Since  $|z| =: r$  satisfies the hypotheses of Lemma 2.2(1), that lemma gives  $\log |a| \geq p_n(z) - L_n$ . Hence, for  $s \geq 0$ ,

$$\{p_n(z) - \log |F_n(z)| > s + L_n\} = \{|F_n(z)| < e^{p_n(z) - L_n - s}\} \subseteq \{|a\xi_k + w| < |a|e^{-s}\}.$$

Now write  $\Omega = \overline{\mathbb{D}} \times \Omega'$ , where the first factor carries the coordinate  $\omega_k$  and  $\Omega' = \overline{\mathbb{D}}^{\mathbb{N} \setminus \{k\}}$  carries the remaining coordinates, and correspondingly  $\mathbb{P} = m_{\overline{\mathbb{D}}} \otimes \mathbb{P}'$ . Because  $w$  is  $\mathcal{G}$ -measurable it is a function of  $\omega' \in \Omega'$  alone, so Tonelli's theorem gives

$$\mathbb{P}\{|a\xi_k + w| < |a|e^{-s}\} = \int_{\Omega'} m_{\overline{\mathbb{D}}}\{\zeta \in \overline{\mathbb{D}} : |a\zeta + w(\omega')| < |a|e^{-s}\} d\mathbb{P}'(\omega').$$

For each fixed  $\omega'$  the inner measure is at most  $(e^{-s})^2 = e^{-2s}$  by (7), with  $\varepsilon = |a|e^{-s}$ ; the bound is uniform in  $\omega'$ , so integrating over  $\Omega'$  preserves it. This proves (8).  $\square$

The pointwise estimate is used through the following circle-average bound.

**LEMMA 2.4** (Circle-average upper tail). *Let  $Y \geq 0$  be jointly measurable on  $\Omega \times [0, 2\pi]$  and suppose that*

$$\mathbb{P}\{Y(\cdot, \theta) > s\} \leq e^{-s/2}, \quad s \geq 0,$$

*uniformly in  $\theta$ . Put  $\overline{Y} = (2\pi)^{-1} \int_0^{2\pi} Y(\cdot, \theta) d\theta$ . Then*

$$\mathbb{P}\{\overline{Y} \geq t\} \leq 2e^{-t/8}, \quad t \geq 8.$$

**PROOF.** The tail hypothesis and the layer-cake formula give

$$\mathbb{E}Y(\cdot, \theta) = \int_0^\infty \mathbb{P}\{Y(\cdot, \theta) > s\} ds \leq 2$$

for every  $\theta$ . Hence  $\mathbb{E}\overline{Y} \leq 2$  by Tonelli's theorem, and  $\overline{Y}$  is integrable. Put  $E = \{\overline{Y} \geq t\}$  and  $q = \mathbb{P}(E)$ . Then  $t\mathbf{1}_E \leq \overline{Y}\mathbf{1}_E$ , and Tonelli's theorem gives

$$tq \leq \mathbb{E}(\overline{Y}\mathbf{1}_E) = \frac{1}{2\pi} \int_0^{2\pi} \mathbb{E}(Y(\cdot, \theta)\mathbf{1}_E) d\theta.$$

For every  $\theta$ , the layer-cake formula and

$$\mathbb{P}(\{Y(\cdot, \theta) > s\} \cap E) \leq \min\{q, e^{-s/2}\}$$

yield

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}(Y(\cdot, \theta)\mathbf{1}_E) &\leq \int_0^\infty \min\{q, e^{-s/2}\} ds \\ &= \int_0^{2\log(1/q)} q ds + \int_{2\log(1/q)}^\infty e^{-s/2} ds \\ &= 2q \log \frac{e}{q}, \end{aligned}$$

where the computation assumes  $0 < q \leq 1$ . If  $q > 0$  we may cancel  $q$  and obtain  $t \leq 2\log(e/q) = 2 + 2\log(1/q)$ , so  $q \leq e^{1-t/2}$ . For  $t \geq 8$  we have  $e^{1-t/2} = e^{1-3t/8} e^{-t/8} \leq e^{-2} e^{-t/8} \leq 2e^{-t/8}$ . The case  $q = 0$  is immediate.  $\square$

### 3. Zero-free disks and proof of the theorem

We first isolate the geometric gain that drives the estimate. For  $c \in \mathbb{C}$  and  $r > 0$  set

$$\gamma(c, r) = \frac{1}{2\pi} \int_0^{2\pi} |c + re^{i\theta}| d\theta - |c|.$$

LEMMA 3.1. *For all  $c \in \mathbb{C}$  and  $r > 0$  we have  $\gamma(c, r) > 0$ .*

PROOF. Set

$$\varphi(\theta) = |c + re^{i\theta}| + |c - re^{i\theta}| - 2|c|.$$

The triangle inequality gives  $\varphi \geq 0$ , and  $\varphi$  is continuous. If  $c = 0$ , then  $\varphi \equiv 2r > 0$ . If  $c \neq 0$ , choose  $\theta_0$  with  $re^{i\theta_0} = irc/|c|$ . The Pythagorean identity gives

$$\varphi(\theta_0) = 2\sqrt{|c|^2 + r^2} - 2|c| > 0.$$

Thus continuity implies  $\int_0^{2\pi} \varphi(\theta) d\theta > 0$ . The substitution  $\theta \mapsto \theta + \pi$  gives

$$2\gamma(c, r) = \frac{1}{2\pi} \int_0^{2\pi} \varphi(\theta) d\theta > 0,$$

as required.  $\square$

Next we record the mean value step in the exact form needed, with the strict radius margin made explicit.

LEMMA 3.2 (Mean value property on a zero-free disk). *Let  $c \in \mathbb{C}$  and  $\rho > 0$ , let  $G$  be holomorphic and zero-free on  $B(c, \rho)$ , and let  $0 < r < \rho$ . Then*

$$\frac{1}{2\pi} \int_0^{2\pi} \log |G(c + re^{i\theta})| d\theta = \log |G(c)|.$$

PROOF. The disk  $B(c, \rho)$  is convex, and  $G'/G$  is holomorphic on it because  $G$  is zero-free there. Every holomorphic function on a convex domain has a holomorphic primitive [5, Chapter IV], so there is a holomorphic  $h$  on  $B(c, \rho)$  with  $h' = G'/G$ . Then  $(Ge^{-h})' = e^{-h}(G' - Gh') = 0$  on the connected set  $B(c, \rho)$ , so  $Ge^{-h} \equiv \kappa$  for a constant  $\kappa$ , and  $\kappa \neq 0$  because  $G$  is zero-free. Choose  $\lambda \in \mathbb{C}$  with  $e^\lambda = \kappa$  and set  $g = h + \lambda$ ; then  $e^g = G$  on  $B(c, \rho)$ , and hence  $\operatorname{Re} g = \log |G|$  there.

The strict inequality  $r < \rho$  gives  $\overline{B(c, r)} \subset B(c, \rho)$ , so the circle  $|z - c| = r$  and its interior lie in the domain of  $g$  and Cauchy's integral formula [5, Chapter IV] applies:

$$g(c) = \frac{1}{2\pi i} \int_{|z-c|=r} \frac{g(z)}{z-c} dz = \frac{1}{2\pi} \int_0^{2\pi} g(c + re^{i\theta}) d\theta,$$

the second equality by the parametrisation  $z = c + re^{i\theta}$ ,  $dz = ire^{i\theta} d\theta$ . Taking real parts gives the assertion.  $\square$



Now fix  $c \in \mathbb{Q} + i\mathbb{Q}$  with  $c \neq 0$  and a rational  $R$  with  $0 < R < |c|$ , and put

$$r = \frac{R}{2} < R, \quad (9)$$

so that  $\overline{B(c, r)} \subset B(c, R)$  with a strict radius margin. On the circle  $|z - c| = r$  we have

$$0 < \delta := |c| - r \leq |z| \leq |c| + r =: M,$$

the left inequality because  $r < R < |c|$ . Consequently there is an integer  $n_0 = n_0(c, R) \geq 1$  such that

$$1 \leq \delta \sqrt{n} \quad \text{and} \quad M \leq \sqrt{n} \quad \text{for all } n \geq n_0, \quad (10)$$

and then the hypotheses of Lemma 2.3 hold at every point of the circle  $|z - c| = r$ , uniformly in  $\theta$ .

To obtain a real-valued measurable deficit without changing it on the zero-free event used below, define

$$\ell(w) = \begin{cases} \log |w|, & w \neq 0, \\ 0, & w = 0, \end{cases} \quad D_{n,z} = \max\{p_n(z) - \ell(F_n(z)) - L_n, 0\},$$

and, for  $n \geq n_0$ ,

$$\overline{D}_n = \frac{1}{2\pi} \int_0^{2\pi} D_{n,c+re^{i\theta}} d\theta.$$

The function  $\ell$  is Borel measurable on  $\mathbb{C}$ , and  $(\omega, z) \mapsto F_n(\omega, z)$  is jointly continuous, so  $(\omega, \theta) \mapsto D_{n,c+re^{i\theta}}(\omega)$  is jointly measurable on  $\Omega \times [0, 2\pi]$  and  $\overline{D}_n$  is a measurable function of  $\omega$ .

Because  $\ell(w) \geq \log |w|$  for every  $w \in \mathbb{C}$  in the extended-real order, with equality unless  $w = 0$ , we have, for  $s \geq 0$ ,

$$\{D_{n,z} > s\} \subseteq \{p_n(z) - \log |F_n(z)| > s + L_n\}.$$

Combining this with Lemma 2.3 and using  $e^{-2s} \leq e^{-s/2}$  for  $s \geq 0$  gives the tail hypothesis of Lemma 2.4 explicitly: for  $n \geq n_0$ , every  $z$  on the circle  $|z - c| = r$  and every  $s \geq 0$ ,

$$\mathbb{P}\{D_{n,z} > s\} \leq \mathbb{P}\{p_n(z) - \log |F_n(z)| > s + L_n\} \leq e^{-2s} \leq e^{-s/2}. \quad (11)$$

So Lemma 2.4 applies to  $Y(\omega, \theta) = D_{n,c+re^{i\theta}}(\omega)$  and to  $\overline{Y} = \overline{D}_n$ .

Let

$$H_n(c, R) = \{\omega \in \Omega : F_n(\omega, \cdot) \text{ has no zero in } B(c, R)\}.$$

LEMMA 3.3.  $H_n(c, R) \in \mathcal{F}$ .

PROOF. We claim that

$$H_n(c, R) = \bigcap_{\substack{\rho \in \mathbb{Q} \\ 0 < \rho < R}} \left\{ \omega : \min_{|z-c| \leq \rho} |F_n(\omega, z)| > 0 \right\}, \quad (12)$$

the minimum being attained because  $z \mapsto |F_n(\omega, z)|$  is continuous and  $\overline{B(c, \rho)}$  is compact. If  $\omega \in H_n(c, R)$  and  $0 < \rho < R$ , then  $\overline{B(c, \rho)} \subset B(c, R)$ , so  $|F_n(\omega, \cdot)|$  is continuous and strictly positive on a compact set and its minimum there is positive. Conversely, if the right-hand side contains  $\omega$  and  $z \in B(c, R)$ , choose a rational  $\rho$  with  $|z - c| \leq \rho < R$ ; then  $|F_n(\omega, z)| > 0$ . This proves (12), and the intersection is countable.

It remains to check that, for fixed  $\rho \in (0, R)$ , the function

$$M_\rho(\omega) = \min_{|z-c| \leq \rho} |F_n(\omega, z)|$$

is  $\mathcal{F}$ -measurable. Let  $Q_\rho = (\mathbb{Q} + i\mathbb{Q}) \cap B(c, \rho)$ , a countable set that is dense in  $\overline{B(c, \rho)}$ : boundary points are approached from inside the disk and then by points of  $\mathbb{Q} + i\mathbb{Q}$ . For fixed  $\omega$  the function  $z \mapsto |F_n(\omega, z)|$  is continuous on the compact set  $\overline{B(c, \rho)}$ , and a continuous function on a compact set has the same infimum over the set as over any dense subset of it; hence

$$M_\rho(\omega) = \inf_{z \in Q_\rho} |F_n(\omega, z)|.$$

For each fixed  $z$  the map  $\omega \mapsto |F_n(\omega, z)|$  is measurable, as noted after (3), so  $M_\rho$  is a countable infimum of measurable functions and is therefore measurable. Consequently  $\{M_\rho > 0\} \in \mathcal{F}$  for every rational  $\rho \in (0, R)$ , and (12) exhibits  $H_n(c, R)$  as a countable intersection of sets in  $\mathcal{F}$ .  $\square$

We can now estimate  $\mathbb{P}(H_n(c, R))$ . Fix  $n \geq n_0$  and work on the event  $H_n(c, R)$ , on which  $F_n$  is holomorphic and zero-free on  $B(c, R)$  by the definition of that event. Since  $r = R/2 < R$  by (9), Lemma 3.2 applies with  $G = F_n$  and  $\rho = R$  and gives

$$\frac{1}{2\pi} \int_0^{2\pi} \log |F_n(c + re^{i\theta})| d\theta = \log |F_n(c)|. \quad (13)$$

Lemma 2.2(2), applied with  $R$  replaced by  $|c|$  and evaluated at  $z = c$ , gives

$$\log |F_n(c)| \leq p_n(c) + C(c), \quad C(c) = \frac{|c| + |c|^2}{2}. \quad (14)$$

On  $H_n(c, R)$  we have  $F_n(z) \neq 0$  for  $z \in \overline{B(c, r)}$ , so  $\ell(F_n(z)) = \log |F_n(z)|$  there and therefore  $D_{n,z} \geq p_n(z) - \log |F_n(z)| - L_n$  on the circle  $|z - c| = r$ . Averaging over that circle and using

$$\frac{1}{2\pi} \int_0^{2\pi} p_n(c + re^{i\theta}) d\theta = \frac{1}{2} \log(n!) + \sqrt{n} \cdot \frac{1}{2\pi} \int_0^{2\pi} |c + re^{i\theta}| d\theta = p_n(c) + \gamma(c, r) \sqrt{n},$$

together with (13) and (14), we obtain on  $H_n(c, R)$  that

$$\overline{D}_n \geq p_n(c) + \gamma(c, r) \sqrt{n} - \log |F_n(c)| - L_n \geq \gamma(c, r) \sqrt{n} - C(c) - L_n =: T_n,$$

that is,

$$H_n(c, R) \subseteq \{\overline{D}_n \geq T_n\}, \quad T_n = \gamma(c, r) \sqrt{n} - C(c) - 2 - \log(n+1). \quad (15)$$

By Lemma 3.1 we have  $\gamma(c, r) > 0$ , and  $C(c) + 2 + \log(n + 1) = o(\sqrt{n})$ , so there is  $n_1 = n_1(c, R) \geq n_0$  with

$$T_n \geq \max\left\{\frac{1}{2}\gamma(c, r)\sqrt{n}, 8\right\}, \quad n \geq n_1. \quad (16)$$

For  $n \geq n_1$ , Lemma 2.4 together with (11), (15) and (16) gives

$$\mathbb{P}(H_n(c, R)) \leq \mathbb{P}(\bar{D}_n \geq T_n) \leq 2e^{-T_n/8} \leq 2 \exp\left(-\frac{\gamma(c, r)}{16} \sqrt{n}\right). \quad (17)$$

The right-hand side of (17) is summable, since  $\exp(-\gamma(c, r)\sqrt{n}/16) \leq n^{-2}$  for all large  $n$ , and the finitely many terms with  $n < n_1$  are each at most 1. Hence

$$\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \mathbb{P}(H_n(c, R)) < \infty. \quad (18)$$

All the events involved are measurable by Lemma 3.3, so the first Borel–Cantelli lemma [6, Section 2.3] applies and shows that

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\limsup_{n \rightarrow \infty} H_n(c, R)\right) = 0; \quad (19)$$

that is, almost surely only finitely many  $F_n$  are zero-free in  $B(c, R)$ .

**PROOF OF THEOREM 1.2.** Let  $\mathcal{B}$  be the family of disks  $B(c, R)$  with  $c \in \mathbb{Q} + i\mathbb{Q}$ ,  $c \neq 0$ ,  $R \in \mathbb{Q}_{>0}$  and  $R < |c|$ ; it is countable. We check that every nonempty open set  $U \subset \mathbb{C}$  contains a member of  $\mathcal{B}$ . Since  $U$  is open and nonempty it contains a point  $z_0 \neq 0$ , and there is  $\varepsilon > 0$  with  $B(z_0, \varepsilon) \subset U$  and  $\varepsilon < |z_0|/2$ . Choose  $c \in \mathbb{Q} + i\mathbb{Q}$  with  $|c - z_0| < \varepsilon/4$ ; then  $|c| \geq |z_0| - \varepsilon/4 > 0$ , so  $c \neq 0$ . Choose a rational  $R$  with  $0 < R < \min\{\varepsilon/2, |c|\}$ . Then  $R < |c|$ , and every  $z$  with  $|z - c| < R$  satisfies  $|z - z_0| < \varepsilon/4 + \varepsilon/2 < \varepsilon$ , so  $B(c, R) \subset B(z_0, \varepsilon) \subset U$  and  $B(c, R) \in \mathcal{B}$ .

By (19), for each  $B = B(c, R) \in \mathcal{B}$  there is a  $\mathbb{P}$ -null set  $\mathcal{N}_B$  outside of which only finitely many  $F_n$  are zero-free in  $B$ . The union  $\mathcal{N} = \bigcup_{B \in \mathcal{B}} \mathcal{N}_B$  is a countable union of null sets and is therefore null. With  $\Omega_0$  as in (4) we have  $\mathbb{P}(\Omega_0 \setminus \mathcal{N}) = 1$ ; in particular this event is nonempty. Fix  $\omega \in \Omega_0 \setminus \mathcal{N}$  and let  $f$  be the entire function (2) determined by it.

Then  $f$  is transcendental, because  $\omega \in \Omega_0$  makes every Taylor coefficient of  $f$  nonzero, and  $f$  satisfies (1), which holds for every sample. Let  $U \subset \mathbb{C}$  be nonempty and open and choose  $B \in \mathcal{B}$  with  $B \subset U$ . Since  $\omega \notin \mathcal{N}_B$ , only finitely many  $F_n = f^{(n)}$  are zero-free in  $B$ . Let  $N(U)$  be one more than the largest such index, or let  $N(U) = 0$  if there is no such index. Then every  $n \geq N(U)$  gives a zero of  $f^{(n)}$  in  $B$ , hence in  $U$ . This is the first assertion of Theorem 1.2, and the last assertion follows from it by Lemma 1.1.  $\square$

#### 4. A consequence for a theorem of Boas and Reddy

Under their standing assumption that  $f$  is transcendental, Boas and Reddy assert that if  $f$  is of order at most two and finite type, then  $f$  admits arbitrarily large disks on which infinitely many successive derivatives are zero-free [3, Theorem 1]. They clarify that one fixed disk serves infinitely many derivatives [3, p. 65]. Their later erratum concerns only the construction for Theorem 2 and does not amend Theorem 1 [4].

**COROLLARY 4.1.** *The function in Theorem 1.2 is a counterexample to the assertion of [3, Theorem 1] as printed.*

**PROOF.** Let  $f$  be the function supplied by Theorem 1.2. The estimate (1) places  $f$  in the growth class assumed by Boas and Reddy. For every fixed nonempty disk  $D$ , Theorem 1.2 supplies an integer  $N(D)$  such that  $f^{(n)}$  has a zero in  $D$  whenever  $n \geq N(D)$ . Consequently only the finitely many derivatives with  $n < N(D)$  can be zero-free in  $D$ . Thus no disk, of any radius, is zero-free for infinitely many successive derivatives of  $f$ , contrary to the printed conclusion.  $\square$

#### Declarations

*Use of AI.* During preparation, OpenAI's GPT-5.6 Sol assisted with the small-ball estimate and editing. Anthropic's Claude Fable and Opus and OpenAI Codex assisted with manuscript revision and argument auditing. The author checked all AI-assisted output and takes sole responsibility for the mathematical content and exposition of this article.

*Competing interests.* The author declares no competing interests.

*Funding.* The author received no specific funding for this work.

*Data availability.* No data were generated or analysed in this theoretical study.

#### References

- [1] K. F. Barth and W. J. Schneider, 'On a problem of Erdős concerning the zeros of the derivatives of an entire function', *Proc. Amer. Math. Soc.* **32** (1972), 229–232.
- [2] T. F. Bloom, 'Erdős Problem #906', [erdosproblems.com/906](https://erdosproblems.com/906), accessed 5 August 2026.
- [3] R. P. Boas, Jr. and A. R. Reddy, 'Zeros of successive derivatives of entire functions', *Bull. Amer. Math. Soc.* **79** (1973), 64–65, <https://doi.org/10.1090/S0002-9904-1973-13093-9>.
- [4] R. P. Boas, Jr. and A. R. Reddy, 'Erratum', *J. Math. Anal. Appl.* **49** (1975), 527.
- [5] J. B. Conway, *Functions of One Complex Variable I*, 2nd edn, (Springer, New York, 1978).
- [6] R. Durrett, *Probability: Theory and Examples*, 5th edn, (Cambridge University Press, 2019).
- [7] P. Erdős, 'Some of my favourite problems which recently have been solved', in: *Proc. Internat. Math. Conf., Singapore 1981*, North-Holland Math. Stud. 74 (North-Holland, 1982), 59–79.
- [8] J.-P. Kahane, *Some Random Series of Functions*, 2nd edn, (Cambridge University Press, 1985).
- [9] G. R. MacLane, 'Sequences of derivatives and normal families', *J. Anal. Math.* **2** (1952), 72–87.

Eric Hou, Independent researcher, Los Gatos, California, USA  
e-mail: [eric.x.hou@gmail.com](mailto:eric.x.hou@gmail.com)